

Cancer



■ 8,00,000 cancer cases occur every year in India.

■ Nearly 2,000 people die of tobacco-related cancer every day in India.

Cell Phones and Cancer

You can stop worrying about getting brain cancer from your cell phone. A massive study by the Danish Cancer Society in Copenhagen of just about every private cell phone user in the country shows no link between gabbing on your mobile and brain tumours. The 4,20,000 participants averaged 8.5 years of cell phone use. But there was not even a hint of brain cancer.

Economic prosperity should bring good health. Conventional logic says, in boom time more people have more jobs and more disposable income to spend on health. But that is not quite how the world works. In fact, a strong economy should probably come with a warning label. Christopher J. Ruhm, an economist at the University of North Carolina, reports that when an economy improves, smoking rises, as does obesity, physical activity falls, as the premium on use of time alters habits. "We used to die of dreaded infections earlier," says Dr Purushottam Lal, director of Interventional Cardiology at Delhi's Metro Hospital. "We will die of life—of the way we live—in the future." And lifestyle diseases are typically more expensive to treat. In 2001, the in-patient cost for lifestyle-related diseases was around Rs 29,000 compared to Rs 4,000 for infectious diseases, reports *Healthcare*, a 2004 Ernst & Young report.

Consider Subhash Mitra of Kolkata. He doesn't look 68, but with dark bags under his eyes and creases on his forehead he doesn't look too good, either. His life, these days, revolves round the state-run R.G. Kar Medical College Hospital, where he comes (more often than he would like to)

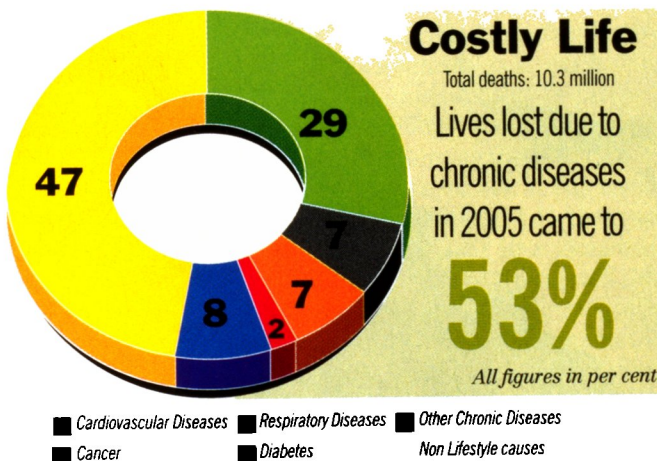
Lifestyle diseases, unfortunately, are the price you pay for progress.

DR S. M. SADIKOT ENDOCRINOLOGIST, JASLOK HOSPITAL, MUMBAI

that nearly 2,000 Indians die of tobacco-related cancers every day.

Others blame the new job scenario and the long hours of work. Take Atul Jalan, 39, founder of high-end software firm, Manthan Systems in Bangalore. He typically puts in 15 hours at work every day and often slogs through the night to catch up with his global clients' convenience. Moreover, in a month, Jalan logs in about 20,000 miles, zooming around the world. "With my schedule, half the time I don't even know if it's day or night," he says. "My diet goes for a toss, and all I am thinking about is the next client meet or the next big deal."

Doctors worry about the habits of people in the software industry—tapping keys for exercise, ingesting untimely food. Dr N. Salgunan, cardiovascular surgeon with Chennai Apollo treats a steady stream of IT professionals. "They work impossible hours, often working in the dark and sleeping during the day. If you work in software, your hours are the office," he says. Recently, he had a 28-year-old heart attack patient from the IT sector. "He was working 16 hours a day."



Source: *Lancet* 2005, 'Responding To The Threat Of Chronic Disease In India' by K.D. Reddy et al

for his check-ups. It's hard to imagine, looking at him, that he was once a successful garment exporter, owned four homes, and enjoyed rental income from those he did not occupy. Diabetes hit when he was 40. He paid it little mind as it pickled his insides. Over the past 15 years, came heart problems and his kidneys deteriorated, too. He had to stop working. To cover the medical costs, he sold three of his homes. His family has been living deep in the suburbs, where it's cheaper, off his fast-evaporating resources.

Historically, people get serious about avoiding disasters only after it smacks them across the face. Medics have been crying hoarse that the worst upsurge of lifestyle diseases in India's history is on us. But a review of disease statistics suggests that modern Indians are particularly bad at protecting themselves from that guaranteed threat. "We know more than we ever did about the dangers we face," says Ramadoss. "But it turns out that in times of crisis, our greatest enemy is rarely the disaster itself. More often, it is ourselves." May many Asiad Colonies bloom in India. ■



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